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Bobby Militello

Saxophonist Bobby Militello was born in Buffalo, NY on May 29, 1950. He has performed with Maynard Ferguson and Bill Holman and currently is a member of the Dave Brubeck Quartet. Bobby is also the owner of Buffalo's premier jazz club, The Tralfadamore Café.

Bobby was interviewed in Buffalo, New York on October 14, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Buffalo, New York filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Bobby Militello with me today. I've been looking forward to talking to you because you see the music business from at least two sides.

BM: At least, yeah.

MR: Whatever possessed you to become a player first?

BM: Well I've always had the talent or the thing about playing, but when I was in fourth grade my mother took me to see the "Benny Goodman Story" and the next day, the next day I went to school and asked could I take clarinet lessons. And we were pretty poor and so the school gave me a clarinet and it started with that.

MR: Wow. Was it a metal one?

BM: Yeah, oh yeah, it was a metal clarinet and it was actually an old Buescher, which I wish I still had, even though it was the metal one I still wouldn't mind having that.

MR: Yeah well they make good lamps too.

BM: Yeah I know. I hate that. When I go into somebody's house and there's a violin on the wall or a saxophone with a light coming out of the bell it's like oh.

MR: It's a very interesting thing that you mention that movie, and people get their inspirations from interesting places.

BM: Um hum.

MR: Were you aware of that type of music before and swing.

BM: Oh yeah.

MR: Before you saw that.

BM: Without a question, yeah. Our house, my mother, God rest her soul, my mother was into jazz and so we grew up on listening to jazz all the time in the house although we didn't get the stereo really until I was about oh I'd say six or seven years old, then we finally got a stereo. Otherwise it was the little radio. And we listened to jazz all the time. And then here in Buffalo we had Sunday afternoons there was "Sinatra and Strings," there was WEBR that had jazz all the time with Joe Rico, who was a great jazz disc jockey at that

time, and so we always listened to jazz in the house and as my brothers got older, because I was the baby, as everybody got older we were introduced to a little bit of R&B type jazz, you know the Lou Rawls and things like that and those kind of things. But basically the context in the house was always jazz.

MR: Specifically whom? Or what kind?

BM: Oh on the radio was everybody, but the first introductions I had, the first album I believe was Maynard Ferguson's "Live at Newport" in '50. And boy I can still scat all of the tunes on that record. I mean I loved that record.

MR: What a band that was.

BM: Oh Jimmy Ford.

MR: That small big band.

BM: All the cats, yeah, I mean that was one hell of a band. And then "Take Five," you know the "Time Out" album. That was the other one that I got. And then we just started buying a whole bunch of things and of course we had this whole entourage of Sinatra albums. And when you're listening to Nelson Riddle and Duke Ellington and all this stuff, I mean you're catching the vibe of exactly what this is about. And then I just started, there used to be a label, Premier, which as I found out later exploited all of the cats that they recorded. But they had, in the eighty-nine-cent-bin in the drug stores, and things like that, you could find Premier label records and it was everybody: Conte Candoli, I had the first album, when I got to play with Conte with Doc Severinsen and the Tonight Show Band, Conte had told me that was the first album him and his brother recorded. And of course they got screwed royally on basically what happened with it but they got an album out and did what they did. And there was a whole bunch of Herbie Mann stuff. One album I bought, Herbie Mann and Sam Most.

MR: Oh yeah.

BM: Remember that album?

MR: Yeah.

BM: Well an interesting little thing about that is a bunch of the solos that say they're Herbie Mann are actually Sam Most.

MR: No kidding.

BM: Yeah. He wanted to sound better on alto.

MR: That's a hoot.

BM: They say it was a mistake in the liner notes, yeah it was a mistake.

MR: Oh right.

BM: But we just started developing this record collection. My mother would buy them when she saw them and I would buy them when I saw them and I would — oh later on we got this Sears Silvertone stereo, which was the stereo man, it was so cool. And I would lay

down in front of this thing and just lift the arm up, when you still had the arm on the record player, and I would put the record on and listen to it over and over and over again, just the one side. And I would just lay on the floor between the two speakers. And I would sort of get into trance, didn't even realize what I was doing to myself but I was programming my computer with licks and I could scat everything that I heard so I was actually scatting them out loud so basically I was working on my vocal chops, not even knowing I was doing that. I was just groovin' and I felt like I was inside the chart because I could sing the lick and do everything. Later on my mother encouraged me to sit there after I'd practiced, because I had a very old school teacher, John Sedola, a great teacher and probably one of the best I've ever known or ever heard of, he is excellent. He taught Don Menza and a whole bunch of different cats, Mike Migliori in New York and a bunch of guys. But he used to make us practice six hours a day. In order to complete the lesson in a week you'd have to do six hours including Sundays, the whole bit. You couldn't play football, couldn't do anything else, you only could do music if you wanted to be with him. So at the end of that six hours, now it was time that I could just do what I wanted to do. And so now I would go out and put a record on and memorize songs and play along with the tunes. And my mother at the time would take the time to sit there in the chair and listen to me blow. And while I was blowing, the first album that I really memorized everything on was Stan Getz, Astrud Gilberto and "Desifinado" and all that stuff on it.

MR: So you were learning his solos?

BM: I was learning his solo verbatim. I'm talking about innuendo, just little lip—

MR: Inflections and all those things.

BM: All the inflections and the licks and the ghosted notes and the things that you do to make it sound like emotional. And my mother would sit there. And I had it down, I mean I had that whole side of the record, every cut down, that I could just play it along with him, exactly the way it was going. But my mother would sit there and say, "Aah today you're just going through the motions." And then another day she'd sit there with a smile on her face and say, "You're playing that solo. You're actually playing the solo." She could hear the difference. It was really amazing. She could actually hear the difference between when you were inside and playing it. And so she used to sit there and say if you're going to go through the motion you might as well just stop it.

MR: That's amazing that you had two real taskmasters. You had — I assume that John Sedola was teaching you classical repertoire?

BM: Yes. Right. His whole thing was in the lesson you only sound like him. He doesn't want you to sound like you or anyone else. You sound like him only. And the idea was that he was teaching you an embouchure control situation that when you really had it down and you knew what you were doing could sound like anybody you wanted, or do anything

that you wanted to do. It's just a matter of adjusting the inside chamber of your throat or the way you grip the mouthpiece, and you just change your sound. And so he was a real, like I said, a taskmaster. And you looked at him like a sensei in karate or something. Your whole purpose for doing well was to satisfy him. And you respected him to no end. And everybody who took lessons with him felt exactly the same way. And just to get in to take lessons with him — he was one of those cats at one time I was playing football for the Lafayette High School team and I was a tackle. And I sprained this finger. And I couldn't practice that week so I came in but I was a good sight reader. So I came in and I'm going through the thing and everything else. And Sedola says, "Well you didn't really practice." I said, "Yeah I didn't practice, I sprained this finger" you know and everything. And he says, "Okay, well, give me the ten dollars." That's how much it was at the time. I gave him the ten dollars and he said, "Okay, now go home, just do the same lesson again. Just practice. This time practice." He says, "I know you can read, but you have to practice," the ten times this, twenty times that. But you have to practice. So go home and practice. And incidentally, it's either football or me. The next morning I handed in my uniform, which really made the football coach mad because I was a big guy tackle and good for the team.

MR: Right.

BM: A funny anecdote is that about 25 years later I'm playing with Brubeck with the Buffalo Symphony. Sold out. In about the fifth row is — I forget his first name, but Rosenbaum, that was the coach, was in the fifth row. So afterwards I come out to get my horn stands, you know, and pick the stuff up off the stage like I usually do after a concert. He comes up and he says "you made the right decision." I says "cool man." And I shook his hand. I says "I know I did."

MR: That is a good story man.

BM: It was really cool man. It was real cool.

MR: When did you start making a connection between the solos you were learning by ear and playing so well — the connection with the harmonies that were going on underneath.

BM: Wow. I'd say sometime in high school. Maybe sophomore year, somewhere around there. There was a point where I was playing with an accordion trio. We were playing a lot of weddings and that kind of thing. The guy played chordovox, the organ type accordion, but before that regular accordion. And I used to like that, Art VanDamne and all those cats. I used to dig the sound. There was a fullness to it that I liked. So in any event, we were doing all these weddings and what we would do it get together on Thursdays, we'd practice for two hours and then watch "I Spy." That was our routine every Thursday. So what we would do is open up a fake book, start reading every tune (there used to be three on a page in the old fake books) so you'd start reading and we'd play through every

single tune, just go through the A's and the B's and the C's and the D's, and then go back and start over again. Week after week. So that when we went to a job we could interpret these tunes that we didn't know when somebody asked for them. So we could make them sound like something. And also, feeding the computer tunes. Inadvertently, by feeding the computer tunes you are also feeding it changes and finding out, oh, that's the same as this. Oh, that's the same as this. Oh that's the same as this. Oh, that will work instead of that because it accomplishes the same — let's say a two-five except different. It's a different way to getting into the same one chord. Cool. All right we could do that on that tune. We could do this on that tune. Well I went home and I had gotten someone to donate a piano that I could have at the house. And I had a piano. And one day I'm playing blues changes and then I realized wait a minute, now wait a minute, you can do this and you can do that. And I started writing out all the alternate changes that I could play on the blues. And I realized at that point, wait a minute, just because it says C7 doesn't mean I have to play a C7. There are a whole bunch of different things that I can play on that chord. That was my first revelation which got me to then Joey Azzorello, Azzorello, a great piano player—

MR: Yes.

BM: And Joey started giving me theory lessons and the *Mehegan Book* and started to say well this is what you found out. This is sort of what that is and this is what the substitute changes represent from your theory. And so we started going through that thing. I'd never really followed that through real far, I think I studied with him for about six months. But the idea was that my head opened up to a new process and that was that I never had to just blatantly play what was in front of my face. Because that truly is jazz. You are always trying to interpret it. So after that point, as you picked up on a little while ago, I'm very much an ear player. And so what it was now, the process was, listen to other things. Listen to Trane. Listen to Cannonball, which I listened to a lot to Cannonball. I mean I think I sound like Cannonball, or I try to. That's the sound in my mind's ear that I try and achieve is that roundness and that beautiful shaped, centered tone. I mean I try and do that. And through hearing them blowing on tunes and listening and listening and listening more and more, and then later Hubert Laws and listening to how he transcended anything having to do with just the normal change that was being played, and then listening to piano players, who all comped, the better players, McCoy and those cats and Bill Evans and the different people behind cats, and Bill Evans behind Miles and Trane and all that kind of stuff. When you listen to Red Garland when he first was starting you are hearing the fact that no longer did they give you the root. They skipped the root out. They pulled that root out and they went third and seven in the left hand sometimes, and then just the upper extension in the right hand. So in the key of C, if you're playing a C7 they might

play a B triad in the right hand and just, you know, E and B flat down here. And what happens is when you do this there is the D change to play on, there's the C7 to play on, but because there's no root, you've got multiple changes to play on from the left hand and you've got multiple changes to play on because you've got a new key here, you've got the left hand key which is not giving you the key of C so you've got a whole bunch you can play on there. All of a sudden I'm listening to this and saying — revelation. Wait a minute. There is really no wrong note. Technically there is no wrong note, you can play anything. It's where you're going, or where you came from. So now get the ear to understand that. Get the ear, but the limitations are when you play with a piano player who doesn't play with the freedom to give you those voicings that my ears say the notes that I'm going to play that normally would be right with a piano player who knows what he's doing, or no piano player at all, right? Now my ear says, no no, you can't do that now because he's stopping you, which is a pet peeve of a lot of soloists. And that's the piano player can put you in a box.

MR: I see.

BM: You know he can do that really easy. So but that's when I learned it, I would say that was in high school. I was playing strip shows at that time, I was doing it six nights a week as a sophomore in high school, doing the strip shows at McMann's, and my teacher, the guy that had a heart attack, that Joey Camara, had a heart attack and they needed somebody right away and my teacher got the call from Hill Munter who was this piano player who I learned a lot from, oh what a great guy he was too. Terrific cat. And he recommended me. He says, "Look he hasn't got the experience but he'll cut it right up, I mean he's a great player." So they hired me and at that time, at 16, it was legal to do that as long as I was working, I had a work permit and you can work. So I went out and did this thing, six nights a week and besides getting a few bras thrown in my face because the chicks always like to fool with you when you're young and doing their schtick to you and that whole bit, besides that kind of a thing Hill taught me how to read a show. And I don't mean a show like when I go out and do Natalie Cole when everything is clear and very succinct, watch the conductor it's marked right, everything is cool, it's also copied very well. I mean I played in Bill Holman's band for five years so I look at his charts, I know what they are. I know how to play a Bill Holman chart just by looking at it. Because Bob Florence, same thing. But I'm looking at those charts, everything is cool. But when you go to read a strip show, where this stripper has been on the road for oh twenty years, or the comedian has been out for thirty years, Johnny Main and all these cats that I backed up. Their books are torn corners, arrows down, scratch this out, put in two extra notes over here, do this, do that. Seg to, and then a name of a tune and what key they want this, and back-up vocalist, don't back-up vocalist, and so you're reading words, you're reading

tunes, you're knowing tunes that you have to insert on an automatic level, and you're interpreting this chart that you can barely even see. And Hill just would teach me relax, he says, this is what you do, you go through this number, and I got it down. I mean I was very good at it and I knew all the tunes, you know, playing "Temptation" for a stripper was just remembering what I heard Earl Bostic, how he played it, that's how I played it. I put the growl in there and just played it like, and people used to flip.

MR: I bet you learned to project in that situation.

BM: Well sure. Well Sedola gave us the projection. Yeah his whole thing was — I used to go to country clubs to hear him play weddings and things like that. And you would walk into a country club, the room was three hundred, four hundred feet long and was one of those typical country club rooms. He's at the other side of the room. I'd walk in the door and you could hear him clear as a bell on the other side of the room with 500 people milling around and doing whatever. You'd just hear his sound clear as a bell. His thing was projection. As a matter of fact when we would play in the practice room together, the other teachers — or the two of us would play together duets and really give it some — the other teachers sometimes would have to stop teaching because we would just vibrate so much that they would say they just had to stop, they just couldn't deal with it. One of us at a time was okay but the two of us, the extra vibration, they just couldn't deal with it. So yeah he taught the projection, which is something I've always said to the kids when we do clinics and that, with Dave and Maynard and everything else. Forget about that microphone. The microphone is a tool that happens later. Right now your whole purpose is to send that sound just like a public speaker looks at the exit sign in the back and that's his focal point.

MR: Right. Sure.

BM: You've got to send your sound out there with that kind of a feeling. If you don't there's always this weakness, you never fit in a section, you'll never work in a section, it doesn't sound right. You will never blend with the lead player. You can never do this.

MR: Yeah. Well a microphone is only going to project what you put into it and if you don't in something good—

BM: Yeah but you need — to have a center in what you do you need to think acoustic. You can't think electronic. You have to think acoustic.

MR: Was your mother cool with you playing strip shows?

BM: Um hum.

MR: That's good.

BM: Well remember, we were fairly poor. And I'm the baby and so my sister had moved out by then and brother Charlie had moved out by then, and Michael was just about to move

out, and so bringing in a hundred sixty a week and a sophomore in high school helped out a lot. And I had my own car and things like that, I mean it was a pretty good situation.

MR: Did you have trouble getting up in the morning?

BM: Once in a while. She threw water on me a couple of times. She actually did that a couple of times. "You've got to get up, you've got to go to school." So then I got a pact with, again, one of the major influences in my life was Sam Scamacca, my high school.

MR: Somaka?

BM: Scamacca. S-C-A-M-A-C-C-A. Sam was cool. Sam was great. And he ended up being the principal there, retired as principal, the whole bit. But when I would go to school Sam basically said okay we've got History of Music first period, whatever music course second period and then you've got gym. Well he'd give me a note for gym and then let me sleep through my first two classes only under the guise that I would get no less than 100 on the tests. He says, "You know a lot of this. This theory stuff, you know it already. Sedola gave it to you. You already know it." He said, "And the History of Music you have to read. As long as you get 100 on your test, not 99, 100, that means I can read it all, and then you can sleep through the first periods." So he would let me stay in the back of the music room and just sleep on a desk.

MR: That's an open mind.

BM: And he would let me out of gym all the time. He would get me out of gym constantly. As a matter of fact that was the thing, we couldn't have — and then the other prerequisite with Sam was that I show up on time for the variety shows because we had — well you know Ronnie Foster? Well Ronnie was in the school with us, he was playing in the school. We had Joey Gaeta who is a guitar player that is out in L.A. who has done at least ten albums or so. And Jerry Panzico who has died recently but he was out in L.A. and a great drummer. And so we had a hell of a big band. I mean a really good big band. And Sam is a horn player but he was an aspiring piano player. So he would play piano with us or Ronnie Foster would do it at certain points in time. Matter of fact Ronnie Foster and I used to skip out of school during lunch and go over to my brother's place, he had a place around the corner, it was like a teen nightclub and there was always a B3 there, and Ronnie and I would go blow for a couple of hours and then we'd come, because I had the key, and then we'd come back to school. It was kind of hip. So Sam, his other prerequisite was that you were on time for all of the things: choir, you had to sing in the choir because he needed in tune voices, and all this kind of stuff. So we did all of it, and he kept us busy and we had the orchestra, I had to play flute or clarinet in the orchestra and then anything else. A couple of times — I remember one variety show where I showed up about 45 minutes late, something like that, and came right in and sat right down and the look he gave me, oh man. He says, "You want what you got? You gotta

pay for it." He says, "This is the last time." And that's the last time I think I was ever late on him. I used to have to play "Taps" because we didn't have a trumpet player that could play taps, so on Memorial Day when we'd go to the park I'd bring my alto and just hold down low B flat and use the harmonic overtone series. [scats] And I was so egotistical even then, that I told him I would only use a school horn because I didn't play my horn outside. What if it rained?

MR: That's funny. I never heard anybody doing — I guess I remember it in the practice rooms, saxophone players doing that, but I never heard anybody actually do it.

BM: Yeah it's actually a good method for teaching intonation and embouchure position. That's part of what I had to do with Sedola was do that kind of a thing and be able to get to the third partial level where you can pretty much play diatonic melodies up in the third partial. And he would have me do this on low B flat, lip slur them with no articulation, which was hard. And eventually just your control of that finite position of your embouchure — because it can make you put your bottom lip over your bottom teeth when you did this. So it was sort of both lips — and it was very hard to do but it really gave you finite control of like how your embouchure opened and closed.

MR: What was your first — is there a time or a circumstance that you considered a break, a big break for you?

BM: Well it depends on what we're talking about, a big break. The first time I soloed and I felt like I actually played a real solo that came from me, I was about 16 years old in a bar on Grant and Ferry around the corner from my house with an R&B band.

MR: Wow. It must have made an impression on you at the time, for you to remember that.

BM: I remember just the whole night. I can still see that room right now, yeah. Things like that, I just never ever forget. Plateaus. When you crack those certain plateaus, you never forget it. At least I haven't. I can remember all the points where I found out the switch — I just moved a level. And this was my first one, to play a solo that I felt like appropriate, imaginative and the whole bit, and even the cats that night, I mean just when the set was over they were all like, oh man. You were burning, man. I walked out of there, like I keep using the analogy that it's like when you get out of confession. That feeling that you have when you walk outside and everything smells fresh, and everything looks good. That's the kind of feeling that I had. When I walked out that door it was like — cool man, I'm a player man. And the first big break: see I don't know whether you equate the big breaks to the big name people or whether you equate them to circumstances and things that had an important impact on your life. The first big break. When I was with the New Wave, actually the New Wave was a big break. That was a band in the seventies. And all we did for a year that I was with them was rehearse, write new tunes, new charts, play the stuff that Tommy Sapienza wrote for us, and we had a vocalist that could scat great, Barbie

Rankin. She could scat great, sang really well, and would learn her parts just like any other horn player would. And we started doing like Ella charts, all these hip things, the stuff from Nancy Wilson/Cannonball Adderley.

MR: Ooh. My favorite.

BM: Yeah. We started doing all those charts. Sap wrote them all out. And then I started, myself and Dave Javonne, when he was with us, another saxophone player here in Buffalo, started transcribing some of the tunes from Phil Woods' albums and we'd write out his solo and then give it to her to learn. And then we'd write them in three parts and then we'd have alto, tenor and vocal, and we'd play them; or we'd do just like John Dankworth and Cleo Laine, where you play the unison line with the scatted vocal. And then we started doing flute on top. And we were like grooving. I mean we were really like looking for it. Long hangs at the house every night 'till eight in the morning rapping about jazz, doing everything else. All the big jazz players that would come into town ended up over the house for a hang, and we were working a lot. And we would actually move a grand piano to our gigs when we got them. We had a Baldwin baby grand that Tommy had, and we'd have it moved. And that's if we had — most of the gigs were six nights a week then. If we had more than two weeks we would move the piano at our expense. We had our own tuner that would come it and the whole bit.

MR: You guys were serious.

BM: Yeah. And we weren't making any money at all. I think I made five grand that whole year. And I learned more and broke more plateaus in soloing and the understanding of jazz during that period I think, almost than during any period of my life. We were working at it and we were grooving. Absolutely grooving. And it was a great thing. During that period is when Maynard heard us opening up at the Landmark, which was a big bowling alley, but Maynard was playing in the banquet room here in Buffalo and we were opening up for him and he heard us there. Actually he first needed an alto player so he called Mike Migliore, who was with the band, with New Wave too. So Mike went out there, and not even three months later Bruce Johnstone decided to split. So then Mike calls me up and he says, "Hey man, you want to play with Maynard?" I say well hell yeah. I dreamed about it when I was a kid. Sure I want the gig. He said, "It's on bari." I says oh man. All right I'll do it. So I went and borrowed a bari, because I'd never played bari, I was always alto, tenor, soprano, flute, clarinet. So I borrowed a bari. I knew I could do it. I mean it was a saxophone. So I borrowed a bari and went out and got the gig instantly. So then I went, he said the next tour starts in two weeks in such-and-such New York. So I flew to New York a day early, went to Manny's. They had two baris, one with a low A and one without. I said I'll take the one without. Because I hated the low A baris. I hated the balance of the horn. It didn't play bop real well. It didn't feel right. So I

bought the one with the B flat. Maynard said that was cool, I didn't have to worry about it. All the writers hated me because they all wrote low A's. But that didn't bother me either. So I started playing bari with Maynard. And that was a childhood dream. That, and playing with Brubeck were both childhood dreams. And so that was really my first big break as far as now playing with someone big. Previous to that in Buffalo here I had gotten to play with/back up Ella Fitzgerald and Tony Bennett. There is one for the books right there. Again, the experiences you'll never ever forget in your life. I walk in, the section is basically Sedola is in the section but it's all Sedola students. Tony Carreri, myself, Vic Kyoto, Russell Dielba and somebody else. It was all Sedola students. Okay? I'm playing the tenor chair. This is when "Something" and all those tunes were out, right? That big album that he had. He got "It Don't Mean a Thing if it Ain't Got that Swing" and all that stuff. So I got the tenor chair, and I've got an alto flute double, a flute double and a clarinet double. Who walks out to conduct us is Torrie Zito. I go well this is poo man. So we start to do the rehearsal and Torrie stops the orchestra and he says, "Who's the sound technician here?" And the guy raises his hand. He says, "Okay strike every microphone except for the solo microphone for the sax player and for Tony." What do you mean? He said, "Man, take a break orchestra." Because this was a full orchestra gig. Take a break. He wants this gig one hundred percent acoustic. And he doesn't like what the guy — strike everything. So they strike everything off the stage, two mics. Now we come back and we start to play and of course a good conductor is going to play something to find out what the soloist can do. He's got to know before he gets into the gig. So we've started off with "Something." And I'm sitting in the middle of that orchestra and we start to play the chart and I can barely play because it's so beautiful and I can hear the changes so clear. I mean every nuance, every moving part I can hear it clear as a bell because it's acoustic. So I can hear everything from my position. So now he gets up to back up Tony on "Something." And I start to blow. Can I swear?

MR: Of course.

BM: Is that okay? I just say fuck the changes. I'm not going to look at the book, I know the tune. Let this work. Let this do what it does. So I started to blow and I'm in freaking heaven. As a matter of fact in my mind, Tony's in my way, I want to blow out the whole thing. It's one of those type of numbers. So I play and then I play the solo and instead of playing the written solo there I just blow. I take my shot. We finish the tune and Tony turns around, he just looks at me. He says, "Okay before we do this we've got to open this up over here, we've got to open this up over here, let the kid play over here, do this and that." I'm like 17.

MR: Whoa, you're 17?

BM: I'm flipping out man.

MR: He's opening up the charts for you.

BM: And Sedola is sitting there like — one of these numbers you know what I mean? He's my kid, he's my boy.

MR: That's super.

BM: That's a time you'll never forget in your life. Never, ever. I was high as a kite. I felt extraordinarily good. And it was difficult, like backing up Ella, Nancy Wilson, a couple of other people, there was those points in time when you get up to blow and — not that long ago, five years ago, when I did Rosemary Clooney with Sam Noto, the two of us with Joe Coccuzo and all the cats from New York, we did it at the Art Park, and I was on tenor on that gig and we were in a rehearsal and we started to blow and read through the tunes and do the stuff and then I get to the soloing behind her or with her, whatever the case may be, and she turns around and says, "You've been with me my whole life."

MR: Wow.

BM: Like cool. I'm doing the gig. And that's exactly what you want to know. That vocalist feels comfortable. She feels like she's in her element because I'm playing the style of the chart. That's another thing I've done my whole life.

MR: Yeah well that takes a lot of musicality.

BM: I don't try and just blow arbitrarily because I'm a cool jazz player and I can play outside so I'm going to play that way on her chart. If you hired me you hired me to play the way I play. I play the chart the way the chart feels, the era, writer, the mood, the vocalist, that's the way you try and interpret a chart. That's the important way to play. And so you draw on a lot from that. I mean I had all the years of listening to cats blow, Ben Webster, all the different guys. If you're going to play the right way on the thing, when she's got a sexy little ballad that she wants to sing and she wants that mood set for her, and also Mark Murphy taught me a long time ago, I used to sit in with Mark because he used to play here in Buffalo, this is like a second home to him. And Mark would let me sit in. And Mark, you can't just like try and blow in the spaces because Mark fills them in. He fills in — he's a horn player as much as a vocalist, so you learn how to stay out of the way but enhance the melody. Sometimes it's a counter line — instead of trying to blow, just a new melody that sits underneath and just gives him, like orchestrators do. So when I back up a vocalist that's the kind of way I try and interpret. I don't just try and stick in jock licks, rather to try and become part of the composite. And she dug it a lot. We had a great time that night, just a super time that night. So I mean there has been different things that I would say are the breaks. Getting the gig with Maynard, that was like I was elated. Absolutely elated. And I was happy as hell. I ended up to be his road manager for three of the four years that I was with him, and did a lot for him that way too. And I love him today as much as the first day I joined him and before I knew him. But at one point

there Migs left — Migliore left, and I asked if I could move to the alto chair and he wanted me on bari so he said no, and then Eric Traub left and I asked if I could move to the tenor chair and he said no I want to keep you on bari. That was the last straw.

MR: Eric Traub?

BM: Yeah.

MR: There's a name that I know from Fredonia. I'll be darned.

BM: Yeah his nickname was Zembo Mosque.

MR: Yeah? Really?

BM: Zembo Mosque. That was the gig that we played when he first got on the band. That was the first gig. Zembo, some Mosque somewhere, and they nicknamed him that. But when I knew that I was destined to play bari forever with Maynard, I gave my notice and said I had to leave. And we left great friends too. There was no hassle there at all.

MR: How does he keep up physically with what he does?

BM: He's very into his yoga and his thing that he does that way and all that stuff. And he's a road rat. Road rats tend to be able to deal with the road and the turmoils and the physical stresses and that kind of stuff. You know I'm a heavy guy and everything else and our schedule with Dave is busy as hell. And yet you tend to deal with it. You figure it out and you make it work. He's done well. I mean he's in pretty good shape. He's gained a little weight but — the last time I saw him I said, "It looks good on ya, man." He's always been on diets and done things and stuff like that. But he seemed to be in pretty good shape. But getting the gig with Maynard and then leaving Maynard, I did a gig for a year in Florida after I left Maynard with Dick Fadele, a local guy, and again did an album with him that's great and a bunch of things, and then after that came back and started a fusion band in Buffalo. And about two years into having a fusion band, Rick James used to come to see me all the time and bring his whole band in, because he said, "Listen to the precision of these guys playing," I mean a quintet sounds like freaking a big band. Because we'd write everything out. Everything was very precise. During that period of time is when I got a phone call from Brubeck. 1981 actually. And I remember being in the house and my wife is in the other room cooking something and I get a call on the phone. "Hi is Bobby Militello there?" I says, "Yeah." He says, "This is Dave Brubeck." I said, "Yup, who is this?" One of those type of things. He says, "This is Dave Brubeck, calling you from New York." "Okay what do you want?" I'm still figuring something is coming at me. "Well we want you to come and audition for the band if you would, in New York, next week. I need a horn player." I says, "Oh yeah, how'd you get my name?" He says, "Well you remember playing the Sugar Bush Jazz Festival in 1977?"

MR: Oh my.

BM: I says, "Yeah, with Maynard Ferguson?" All of a sudden I'm realizing there's some truth in who this is on the phone. And he says, "Well you played that flute solo," he says, "well my wife was out in the crowd and she heard you and came back to get me." I came out and only heard the last 30 seconds, maybe minute of your solo, but twenty thousand people stood up and cheered when you finished. And he said, "That sort of said something. But my wife said you were a phenomenal player. So we wrote your name down in the book that day, our day book. We went back, went through seven or eight years of day books until we found your name, called up Maynard and asked him where you were and he gave us your number in Buffalo." I says, "All right." He says, "So would you want to come?" I says, "Yes." Went there, he sent me a book of tunes, new tunes that they were doing of course, they weren't doing all the old quartet stuff. But when I go to do the audition they were preparing for a gig they had to do in New York and who is there is Joe Morello and Eugene Wright.

MR: No kidding.

BM: So I walk into the original quartet, which is like a dream, I mean I had memorized all those Desmond things and all that stuff. So I walked in and had done my homework on the new tunes. But I didn't have to do my homework on the old tunes because I already knew them. So Dave says, "Well what do you want to play?" I said, "Anything you want. Anything you want to play." And he tells this in his interviews now to people. So he says, "Play some of the new tunes" and I played them right out. That's cool. And then they were fooling around with something and they started playing "Kathy's Waltz" and I jumped on that one. And then there was another, I forget which other one we did of his tunes but I jumped on that one too and played that one. And I even was freaking him out once in a while, which Joe Morello told me later did freak him out, on a couple of other gigs we did for the Seeing Eye Dog Foundation with the original quartet, to raise money for them, where he says when he was playing and he closed his eyes and he had to kind of get into it but because I would emulate Paul he really would get like this bizarre feeling for a second of being back, you know, one of those type of things. But basically then we started fooling around with standards and doing a bunch of things, and whatever he wanted to play I played. I didn't care what key, we didn't talk about keys, he says, "All right, you've got the gig." It was great. So I left. He never asked about the bread. Ever. Didn't ask when I got the call for my first gigs. I went out and played them and didn't ask. I got my checks in the mail. I had no idea what I was going to make and it made no difference whatsoever. None whatsoever. And that was a major break. Playing with Doc Severinsen, that was a major break, with the Tonight Show I sat in the orchestra here in Buffalo back, just as a contract player. And then he hears me play and the cats all in his band knew me because of the years we'd been blowing the solos and all of a

sudden he falls in love. Now the next time he comes back to Buffalo there's four saxophone solos that he's put in there because he knows I'm here. And he's asking for me. Now he takes me out to do a couple of other orchestra dates with him, in other cities, and then asked me if I wanted to do the Tonight Show band when they take it on the road. I said yeah, hell yes. And I get to go out on the road, on a bus, and hang out with Conte Candoli, Snooky Young, you know, all the cats. The real deal. I mean these cats have been doing it for ages. They've got stories, I mean just ridiculous, just ridiculously fun hang, and the second time I go out, who's playing the other tenor chair is Ernie Watts. And I'm like I transcribed your stuff, and I've got tunes that you wrote that I've done out when you were with Bruce and doing all that stuff and everything else. So we started playing. And Doc of course, he's got two shooters here. So he's going to give us a tune where the two of us blow and blow off each other. And we do that thing, and it was so out, I automatically, because of my ears, I will try and cop the style of what I hear. He does the same thing, he's copping me. And I've never heard anybody do it. I've never heard anybody do that. It was so funny it was great. So that was a major—

MR: Well gosh have you ever had anything that went terribly bad?

BM: No.

MR: That's good. All that preparation paid off.

BM: Musically never. I've left things that I didn't like, but musically never, I've never had one go bad on me or one that I couldn't do, whether it was R&B, funk, whatever it was, I could still do it. But preference now is bop, or getting a little out here and there, but the preference is bop. But no I've never had anything go bad. When I did the album on Motown in '83, it was Bobby M. Blow, it was a funk R&B record. And when I first got the contract when Rick got me that contract, I had all these grandiose ideas of my fusion band being — recording my fusion band. And then Lenny White became the producer, which worked out for me, and we took all those fusion tunes and turned them into R&B. And I saw the writing on the wall and actually at one point my brother, we were in the studio here in Buffalo just working on the tunes and making the transitions. And at one point I went outside and I was almost having like a panic attack, and I started crying, telling my brother, I says, "I don't think this is right." I know the truth of the matter is Motown won't know what to do with a jazz product, a fusion jazz even product, they won't know what to do with it because they don't have anything like it on their label. So I'll give them something and it could be wonderful and then it will probably do nothing. But if I give it an R&B touch then they can deal with it, I mean they can put it out. So I know the business of what I'm talking about. But I feel like I'm bastarding my craft. I've worked for two and a half years on this book of tunes and they're great. I went with the business decision. We're going to go the whole way. We're going to switch it over and

make it R&B and I'm going to blow funky, less notes, do the whole bit. And it did very well actually. But my brother could never understand this in my nature, but I didn't want to do a second, they didn't pick up a second anyways, but I wouldn't have done a second. And I decided, and my brother says, "You could be rich, I mean you could do this well." I says, "I know I could do it well but now that I've done it I have to do it because that's what the people hear, the record. So now I have to play that. But I don't want to play that anymore. Once in a while I like it. One tune, cool. Two tunes, cool. Because I enjoy playing funk. But as a career? No. He says, "Yeah but—" "No you don't understand. It's got nothing to do with the money, Michael, you don't play jazz for the money." And he just couldn't see that. I sing very well, I'm lucky, but I sing very well and I got a kind of a style from Mark Murphy and Carmen McRae and I kind of meshed together. And every time I sing people flip. But I'll only sing one tune a set. Maybe two at the most, but most of the time just one tune a set, or I sing at weddings when I do weddings with my friends I sing Sinatra tunes and Swing stuff. Well without fail, I mean people have offered to back me on a record where I sing, and my brother says, "You've got to sing more tunes in the set and you know you draw more people." "Michael, if I do that then I become the singer that plays saxophone." I says, "That's not what I want to be. I want to play my horn." You know, so don't—

MR: Well it's good to have your priorities in order, it's very important.

BM: It's not about the bread. Everything can't be about the money, it just can't, especially not this, not the craft, not what you do, you can't be about the bread. Yes you want to make it. Yes you want to be successful. But I'll be damned if your criteria is how much money you make, you will not play the same. Some of the best playing I've ever done is gigs for free with Bill Holman in LA, or where you're working for the door and you made seven bucks. That's some of the best playing you did for twelve people. Something like that, where you broke these things and played wonderful. In the rehearsal room with Bill one day I remember flipping everybody out in a couple of solos on "Blue Daniel" and something else. Knocked everybody out. There was no bread. Get in the space, every time you blow, that's the important thing.

MR: Well speaking of money, what's it like to own a club these days?

BM: Speaking of money and how it goes away. It's great. It was an ego trip. Basically it's based — owning a club and like the Tralf, and doing what I do, is basically on my players' ego. I've seen that club since its inception. I was there when it was first opened and as a matter of fact before it was first opened when it was downstairs on Filmore and Main Street.

MR: I played there in seventy — gosh I don't know, seventy seven.

BM: The old one, downstairs.

MR: In the basement.

BM: That was with Ed Lawson, sure. And so I mean I knew what his vision was and I could see it was cool as hell. He just wasn't a very good businessman, but it was the right thing to do. He knew how to make a jazz club and he loved the art. And that's one of the things that's like lacking in a lot of places that are supposedly jazz clubs or music clubs. The person that owns it really has no idea, they really don't. They hire a buyer, they do whatever — the end game of the club then reflects that to me. But I had seen it teeter and fail through the course of the 23 years that it was in its location now that I have. I've had it for seven. The Tralf. And all the way along the way I've always been a businessman and I've always had a propensity toward being able to do business well and understand its concepts. It worked for my brother and different people, and have done other things, road manager for Maynard, myself personally I always do my books meticulously and always learn more about accounting things and stuff like that, it is just the way I work. Always use computers and always tried to make the most out of what I had and never looked at living on — I'm a self-employed musician so that means the money I make this week isn't necessarily the money I have to spend this week. And I've always looked at an amortized situation. It's always been there. So now the Tralf comes up and I had moved back to Buffalo and I had the restaurant across the street, the Bijou Grill with my family, I had invested in that a long time ago. And this comes up and I don't know, it was the mood I was in. I'm with Dave and I've got a lot of things happening and everything else but I said I want to do this. This can be done right. This can make money and it can make people proud and happy in the city. So I went ahead and did it. And — a lot of work. And I didn't make a dollar out of that place for the first — almost four years. It was only putting money in. But it was a labor of love. I knew I could do what it was — I could create my vision of the perfect club. And I did. The sound system is perfect. Literally perfect, it's gorgeous. And the atmosphere is right and the customer service is A triple A. And then my challenge was to build a team of people that could run it so I could stay on the road. Because I told them all and I continue to tell them in meetings, I'm a musician first. This is what I do. I'm gone. When the gig comes along I'm gone. So if it's seven weeks in Europe, which is going to be in ten days, if it's any of those things that's what it is. So now you have to make it work. And I'm always there with e-mail, my European cell phone, my regular cell phone, I'm there to answer the questions and deal with anything that has to be done. So don't take me out of the loop. And I have my opinions and will assert my opinions as time comes up, but in the meantime you know what I want. You have to learn what it is that I would want to do and you have to do that, even if you don't think it's what you want to do. And that's what they do. Customer service is A

628 triple A over there. People enjoy it. We come up with some good deals for people and
629 keep our prices Buffalo real.
630 MR: I was going to ask about that. I had an experience a couple of different times in New
631 York where you go to like the Iridium, and by myself I think I spent $60, and I saw a
632 band that had two very well known musicians on it but was obviously an unrehearsed, it
633 was like a throw together gig you know. Which of course is typical. But I didn't leave
634 feeling great. Because I had to leave after the first set too or pay again. And so as an
635 owner, how do you address my unhappiness?
636 BM: Well number one is I usually put good shows together so I know that my shows that
637 you're going to get are going to be good shows. Some of the jazz shows you don't know
638 who the players are going to be when they come in but for the most part you can tell by
639 knowing, which I know most of the cats so I know what they're like and I know that
640 they'll come in with a good band and the whole bit. So as much as I can I get those
641 details ahead of time and post them with everything — who the sidemen are in the band
642 so everybody can know, which in a lot of circumstances, Lincoln Goines or any of the
643 cats are in the band well that's a selling point. So that's the first thing we do is make sure
644 we put good shows together, whatever kind of shows they are. The second thing is we
645 make sure that the pricing of the show — I have a formula that I used and basically that
646 formula basically breaks the room down into how many seats it has, how much money it
647 costs me to promote the concert and whatever other extremities — back line rentals, etc,
648 etc. Come up with a number. Take that number, take around 65 percent of the seats in the
649 house. That should break me even. Sometimes 70, 75, it depends how much the band
650 really costs you. If I really want — like when I did Pat Methany for three days we ran at
651 85 percent. That means 85 percent of those seats have to be filled or I'm going to lose
652 money on the show. But what you do is you take that, you advertise the cost, you take a
653 look and you see what that ticket price is. Now to make it even fairer you can take and
654 say instead of one ticket price we're going to go with advanced and day of show. If you
655 wait until the day of show you pay more. If you buy them in advance you pay less. Object
656 being that the spread allows me then to reduce the advance ticket price and that the
657 people that buy day of show pay the freight because they prefer not to buy in advance and
658 that's cool, that's fine. So by doing the spread on that level that allows me to drop one or
659 two dollars off that advance ticket price. So basically this is what I mean by Buffalo real
660 prices. Also, negotiating with agents and telling them, hold on guys, we're in Buffalo,
661 you're not in New York, you're not in Philly. Don't hit me with the high ball national
662 rate because you're not going to get it in Buffalo and you're not going to draw the
663 number of people you think you are. But we're going to advertise the hell out of the date.
664 And we're going to make sure everybody knows about it. And we're going to make your

conditions perfect. And you're going to love the club. And it's going to be the right gig, that you're going to want to come back and play my room again. So we'll set you up a gross potential based on what we feel is a reasonable market value for that show in Buffalo. Then we'll put you on a percentage above that if you sell it out completely to the hilt, well then you'll break in a percentage and we'll get close to the number you're looking for. And then the next time you come back we'll raise the price. Well by doing both ends, and that is negotiating with the agents saying this is Buffalo so let's go by Buffalo value and prices, let's not go by New York's. And that's what we do and we come up with this mean and we show them — because we don't lie to them — that when they come in they only drew so many people. And it wasn't the number he thought he was going to do. And I say well that's Buffalo. And understand me, the next time maybe we'll do better. But we've broken most of them in the percentage and they walk out with extra money. Especially Pat Methany, he walked out with his full national bread after three days. He was happy as hell, thought it was great. And the Yellow Jackets and all those cats, I mean they do well. So we've come up with a formula that's based on two sides. You look at number one is the club side and the consumer side, and the other side is the agent side and the act side. And you have to balance the two in order to create this thing. And if you look on our web page or whatever, you'll see that our prices are lower than anybody in the country for these shows. And we all make money. We all make money. Everybody does. The artist leaves happy as hell and everything is cool. And we make a little money in the club on the door. So I don't expect to make too much money on the door. If I can pay for the act, pay for the stuff and everything else and make a couple of dollars I'd be real happy. It's more the bar and the food is what we do, and we take a lot of pride in what we do there. The food is very good. It's short order food but it's very good. My whole thing is customer service. The customer has to be happy. If he isn't he has to be able to communicate why he's not. So there's always a manager on the floor that everybody will direct their complaint, whether it be a waitress or whatever, to the manager on the floor. The manager will make a decision whether it's valid or just a hyped complaint just to get the price down or try and get something. If it's valid we address it and we talk about it in a meeting. They also are free to give out my phone number, not my home number but my office number or my e-mail address, and those people can contact me direct if they think they're getting sidestepped. And they do contact me direct, and I back, usually, my manager's decisions because they were right most of the time. But I do communicate with all of those people myself. And they readily — on the bottom of the web page you can click on Bobby M and get to me anyway, everybody can. So the object is we open up the lines of communication so that people can say what they think is wrong. Right now we're running at around 98 or 99 percent

satisfaction. We only get — we do a little over 120,000 people I think we're going to do this year, maybe a little more than that. We're selling out everything lately. And out of that 120,000 people we probably get maybe 20 complaint letters we got this year so far. Maybe 15. And some of them again are the hyped type ones where they just try and get a gift certificate out of it or something like that.

MR: Well including your performing experience and seeing it from the club owner's side, what's your opinion on the state of jazz in this country these days?

BM: It's great.

MR: You think it's great.

BM: It's wonderful, oh yeah. Those people who think that jazz is still in its demise and whatever, well I mean it's always been the small demo. It's always been that three percent of the record buying market and of that the three percent, they include fusion and Rock and funk and everything else into that three percent. So take even a smaller percentage of that for really aesthetically correct — or whatever — jazz, you know the real jazz. Nothing wrong with fusion stuff especially played well. Chick Corea's Electric Band is a wonderful experience to listen to. I love it. And there's been a whole bunch of fusion I love in my life, so I'm not putting down fusion. But that three percent, probably one percent of that — or 33 percent of that three percent, or one percent is basically really jazz, in the real tradition of jazz. So who are we trying to fool here? I mean we're not trying to become the populist music. We were the popular music when it was big band/swing. We were the rock & roll of that era. Okay? That was what that was. But once rock & roll came into play then that changed okay? Then we were moved out of the slot. And now we can accept one percent. I'll be damned if a car manufacturer can get one percent of the US sales of all cars, that'd be a multi-millionaire. Well there's nothing wrong with being one percent. Nothing wrong with that at all. The fact is there's more jazz festivals sold out everywhere, Newport sells out every single year 'cause we play it. Most of the concerts at Carnegie Hall and at Lincoln Center and those kind of places are sold out every time you play them, or every time you see them. Sometimes good reviews, sometimes bad reviews. But who listens to reviewers? I mean really.

MR: Has it become more of an art music? I'm not sure I'm saying that right but it's been culturally certainly elevated and it's in all the schools now and you know you can go to universities and stuff.

BM: Well that's the reason why I think it's growing — it's actually growing. It's getting bigger all the time. Because the schools have had this music in it since I was in grammar school. So its effect is taking hold and that is a whole series of two generations, maybe three generations of kids have now been exposed to jazz in school, and of those kids maybe only let's say three percent of them really dig it and that's their mainstay music.

But they all have an appreciation for it, because they all played the big band swing tunes in high school bands, and they all played whatever fusion charts and everything were written, you know, Bob Mintzer charts and all the other things — they all played all this stuff. So they have an appreciation for it. And they come out to see the gigs now. And they come out to see the players. They enjoy doing that and they're open to being exposed to jazz. I think you're seeing more people, we sell out everything with Dave. I mean on a scale of one to ten, nine point five of the gigs are completely sold out. Full of kids. Kids coming up to me all the time. I heard your solo on this and I heard your solo on that and wow what this is and what that is. And these are kids and this is an 82 year old guy. It used to be, a while ago, when I first started with Dave 21 years ago, sometimes you'd meet a kid who didn't know who Dave Brubeck was because it was an extension of an era. I mean we moved a shift there and this kid was before that. But very seldom do you meet anybody who doesn't know who Brubeck is now. And the amount of kids again, that are exposed — I think we've got a growth of jazz that is wonderful in the United States. I don't think it's negative in any way, shape or form. The only thing that's negative about it is the people who write about it and talk about it and that kind of thing, who perceive it still as the underground and why can't jazz do so much better. I mean jeez — guys like Sonny Rollins and anybody who's been around for a long time are making great bread out there right now. They're doing fine. They're selling out everything that they do. They can't work enough gigs. Brubeck right now, we turn down almost as much as we take.

MR: I'll bet.

BM: I'm sure Wynton Marsalis has no complaints.

MR: I would think not.

BM: I'm sure there's a bunch of cats that have no complaints about anything, the Heath Brothers are busy as hell, and everybody's working, and Jerry Bergonzi out of Boston is working a lot and flying to Europe all the time and doing things. All right. Not everybody is doing well. Isn't that the way it's supposed to be?

MR: Name a business where everybody's doing well.

BM: Exactly right, or where they're supposed to. You know Bill Holman, if anybody should be a giant in the eyes of the world and completely successful and rich to all ends it should be Bill Holman. Bill Holman is a wonderful writer, arranger, and just he's got a mind on him that is like unique in the world. And he does fine, he does fine, there's no problem, he does fine, but doesn't get the acclaim or the recognition. Say Bill Holman to a bunch of kids — put ten kids in a room and say Bill Holman and you might get nobody, you might with Brubeck you might get one or two or five. But Bill Holman, nobody. So those kind of things I could see why a guy would say oh well Bill Holman should be there.

Well yeah, he should. But there's reasons why he isn't. Because he's the pure art form. He is the real art form. There is no — I'm losing the word I'm thinking of — he's not willing to compromise. It's what it is. It's what I do. That's what I do and here you go. You like that? Cool. Because I'm going to keep doing that. And if you don't like it, that's cool too. But this is the direction I hear and that's where I'm going. And it's unabashed. It's exactly what it's supposed to be. Jerry Bergonzi is an example of a saxophone player who only plays for the love and the art of what he does. He does not think in the solo about making you happy how he's blowing. He just blows unpretentiously. And it's so refreshing to hear somebody do that.

MR: You know just to wrap up here, I wondered if you can describe what you think of when you solo. What do you take into consideration?

BM: I've done some clinics and I've sort of come up with a way, an analogy, at clinics to try and get kids into it. I think of nothing. Absolutely nothing. My best solos are in the black spaces. If you're going to blow — now this I'm going to say — this isn't unequivocally correct, this is my view. If you're going to blow a great solo you can't have analytical thought get in your way. To me, you already have to know the changes and you already have to know what you're going to do. You have to allow your ears and your soul to absorb the vibe of the people around you in such a way that you react and they react instantaneous, without thinking. And the only way that happens is when you go into the space and allow yourself to be free inside the space. And so for me I start to blow and all I do is see nothing. I see a black space. And I can see it — I mean you usually close your eyes and see black, but I can see where I go right now. And I can see it's got a depth to it and I start to blow and I hear what I hear. As a matter of fact I start to blow off what I hear, and if there's nothing there I still hear that. It becomes a different kind of sound. The space becomes a different kind of sound. For me, that's the best way to blow. I don't care what key I'm in, as a matter of fact I don't want to think about — even on blues, I will not think about the key, because it has no real reason — rather there's no reason to think about what key I'm in. What am I going to make a mistake? I mean really, give me a break. Everybody makes mistakes. So you don't care what key you're in, you don't care about anything like that, you care only about the space and the validity of the statements you make. It's like oh try and drive the car — all right you go all the way back to when you first started to drive. You're taking that first lesson. And they're telling you okay you've got to look in this mirror, you've got to look in that mirror, you've got to look in this mirror, you've got to look behind you, you've got to put your seatbelt on, before you put it into gear you've got to do this, you've got to do that. When you depress the pedal don't use both feet because if you use this you'll ride the brake pedal. You have all these rules. Now when you get to the corner look in this direction before you do this and

always look to your left because traffic comes from this direction so you look there first then you look over here. You have all these rules. Try driving the car and thinking about those. You can't. Try playing golf and trying to think about how you put your hands and what you do and the position of your shoulder and where you — no that's for when you practice. But when you go to play the game you're in the zone. When you go to drive the car you're in the zone. You do it inherently because you've practiced enough to do it well. If you do it well great. If you don't you have an accident. If you don't you don't hit the ball right, it slices to the right or it doesn't do what it's supposed to do. But when you're in the zone, when you're truly doing the job, I'll defy anyone to say they were thinking about it when they did it. There's nothing there. It's the pure thought process. I am right inside and it's going direct. That's what I try and get across to the kids when we do clinics. I'm an ear player. I'm a soul player. That's where I give you what I play. See that's what makes the difference between somebody that wants me to play on their movie score than somebody else. Because they know what I'm going to give that melody. It's the name notes in there but they know what I'm going to give it. And that's the difference. They want what I'm going to give it. So you have — when I'm dealing with the kids — you have that ability to do this. So I make them close their eyes. I just did this at the University of the Pacific last week. The kids wanted to know how to play out. And let me tell you these were not — like these were the cream of the crop from around the country, the University of the Pacific has a really unique program where they bring them in on a scholarship thing from all over the United States into one place and do a week of seminars. Christian McBride was there, Brubeck, ourselves. You do seminars, things, work with the kids and everything, and they put bands together, wonderful program. So these kids, I got a quintet standing in front of me and said, "Play me something." And they picked a tune, I think it was "Morning Sunrise" or whatever it is.

MR: "Softly in the Morning Sunrise."

BM: "Softly in the Morning Sunrise." I think that's the one they picked. So they started to play the tune and I listened, now how do you want to start this, what do you want to do. And they started the tune and I listened to it and I says cool, okay, all right. Let's do it again only this time everybody close your eyes. I want to sit quiet for a minute. I want the bass player, drummer, anybody who feels like starting to play, do not think about that melody, don't think about what key you're going to be in, don't think about anything. I don't care if you just want to make noises. Just I want somebody to start something at any point in time, but I want us to sit here for about two minutes with our eyes closed. And then I want anybody to join in. And anybody else join in. And anybody else join. And once you're together as a composite and everybody's kind of blowing, and if you don't feel like getting in there, don't. I says once you're together and you've got the swirl

happening and you've got something going on, you know where you're going, you know the melody of the tune, you know the rough tempo that you want to be at, anybody start it. Anybody start time or start the melody. So to make a long story short, I mean there was a little more explanation in there than that, so I sit back and make everybody sit there with their eyes closed, which was fun too because these young kids, none of them started giggling or anything. Only the one girl was self-conscious. Other than that everybody was pretty into it. So then the bass player started and the piano started but just tinkled like minor seconds. Within a short period of time there was a beautiful conclave of sounds that didn't have a center but it just was beautiful. And then out of there the horn player started to say it, just loose, without time. And they sort of implied the change, the thing came out. The bass player started to lay down a little bit of time and before you know it they were into the tune and a better, much better tempo than they'd picked the first time. They played through the whole thing, their solos, started to do the same thing with — the drummer was taking it out, I mean things were going on and then when they finished the tune they took it out the same way. And I didn't tell them to do that. They just took it out — they let it just kind of disintegrate. And it was cool. When they finished they looked up and me and they all started laughing. And they had this — first they had this serious look on their faces. And they all started laughing. I says "you guys got out there, didn't ya?" They says yeah. That was cool. That's jazz dude. Because right now you can't do that tomorrow again. You can't do it the same way. That's jazz. Don't try and do it the same way. Don't ever, ever try and play it the same way. Try and play different. Today you'll do it real good, tomorrow you won't. So what?

MR: Well there you go. That's some great words of wisdom and well this has been really fascinating.

BM: It's been my pleasure.

MR: I've been pleased to meet you. You've got your act together in a number of venues and so I look forward to visiting your club sometime.

BM: Any time.

MR: And hearing you with Brubeck.

BM: Yeah tonight would be a good night.

MR: All right.

BM: There's a lot of good acts down there.

MR: Great. Thank you so much.

BM: Thank you.